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HIGH SEAS

Few civilian vessels made such a mark on the history of the Cold War as the Soviet dry cargo ship *Ilia Mechnikov*. Built in France in 1956 and named after the famous Russian immunologist and 1908 Nobel Prize winner, the ship could carry more than 3,000 registered tons of cargo, each registered ton occupying 100 cubic feet. In September 1960 it delivered the first ever shipment of Soviet weapons and ammunition to Cuba, including at least ten Soviet T-34 tanks of World War II fame and one hundred pieces of antiaircraft artillery. Long after its Cuban service, in October 1973, during the Yom Kippur War, the *Ilia Mechnikov* was sunk by rocket fire from Israeli boats while visiting the Syrian port of Tartus.[1]

In 1962 the *Ilia Mechnikov* was as busy as ever, first bringing cattle from India to Bulgaria and then making two trips to Cuba, delivering Soviet weapons and troops. The first trip began on August 8, when the ship left its base in Odesa and stopped at the Crimean port of Feodosia to pick up its cargo. According to its official papers, the ship was delivering 1,260 tons of